



26 | ours will grow. As an industry, given our scale and size, we need to be given more credit for how agile we are and how we are able to navigate even though we are very big.

Q: There has been a lot of chatter that hirings have slowed in the IT industry. Do you think it's going to get better soon?

A: I can't comment on the industry. We have been fairly transparent in restructuring. We have hired more higher-skilled people. So, in fact, hiring has picked up a little bit. Hiring is a function of the demand environment. That is driven by what is happening globally, as most of our industry is export-oriented. I think it is going to improve from hereon.

Q: Could you talk about some unique challenges you faced as a woman chairing a global tech corporation?

A: For me, the challenge was not as a woman. I was 39 when I became the chair. A lot of my challenges related to that: when older people look at you, they say you're so young. So, I got 'Oh My God you're so young' more than 'Oh My God you are a woman'. If anything, the tech industry is one place where you

find people of all ages, at all levels of leadership. I hope it is my strength and it is good to be different and the only woman in the room.

Q: How do you foster diversity and inclusion in your own teams?

A: Women form 50% of the board. We foster diversity and inclusion right from the top. When I joined HCLTech, it had only one woman on the board. That has been a conscious effort. We also have phenomenal senior tenured women who I was able to attract, and they come from the industry. It was a conscious decision. I am hoping that this DNA trickles down the organisation. It's not easy. But it must start from the top.

Q: Is it trickling down? Is this also a priority during campus hirings?

A: At the fresher level, the induction of women is almost equal to men. That's not when the fall happens. That happens at pivotal points in their careers, sometimes when they get married. If your husband is posted somewhere, you end up moving. When you decide to start a family, how do you rise through senior leadership roles? That's when the numbers start to drop off. At the board itself, I have a stewardship committee that doesn't just focus on governance and ESG but also on inclusion. The thing about diversity is, it can be a tick on the board, but inclusion is when everyone is growing. Almost all the women who go on maternity leave come back. You have to make it comfortable for them and when they come back you have to make sure they don't lose out on their career path.

Q: What's the best piece of advice you have received from your father?

A: He always tells me and everybody to "stay the course."

Q: What is your advice to women who are aspiring for leadership positions?

A: I am just going to borrow from the HCL credo, "Stay the course." Sometimes as a woman you have to work double as much but if you're committed, you will make it. And there are many women before me who have made it. Keep upskilling yourself. You have to grab every opportunity. It's important to stay authentic because leaders are authentic. **BT**

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